

The Penang Riots of 1867 Reconsidered:

Colonial Security Crisis, Secret-Society Mobilisation and Emergency Rule in the Straits Settlements

A Historical Reconsideration Based on Contemporaneous Colonial Correspondence

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Abstract

The Penang Riots of 1867 are commonly described in later historical narratives as violent clashes between rival Chinese secret societies within George Town, Penang. The surviving Colonial Office correspondence examined within the CO 273 series, however, reveals a considerably broader and more serious colonial security crisis than many later simplified narratives imply.

The records examined in this study reveal not merely communal violence, but organised secret-society mobilisation, weak military capability, inadequate policing strength and growing British fears concerning the ability of colonial authorities to maintain effective control within Penang itself. The correspondence further describes widespread violence involving barricaded streets, armed mobilisation, arson, musket fire and emergency security measures implemented during and after the disturbances.

The riots also triggered expanded executive powers, disarmament operations, commissions of inquiry and broader debate concerning colonial security governance within the Straits Settlements.

This study re-examines the Penang disturbances through original colonial records, with particular attention given to organised mobilisation, military weakness, emergency governance and British perceptions of the crisis during the disturbances of 1867.

Keywords: Penang Riots; 1867; Straits Settlements; secret societies; British Malaya; colonial security; emergency legislation; Penang; contemporaneous evidence; Hai San; Ghee Hin; historiography; Colonial Office records.

Sources and Methodology

This study is based primarily upon archival British colonial correspondence examined within the Colonial Office (CO) records relating to Penang and the Straits Settlements during the disturbances of 1867.

All CO references in this paper refer to records held at The National Archives (United Kingdom), Colonial Office series.

The Colonial Office records examined in this study were accessed through the Gale Primary Sources platform. Researchers should note that Gale image numbering may differ from the original pagination or folio numbering of the archival records.

The surviving correspondence examined in this study primarily reflects British official perceptions and administrative concerns. The perspectives of Chinese secret society members, Malay leaders and ordinary residents are largely absent from the archival record or survive only through the filtering effect of colonial reporting.

The archival material examined includes:

- administrative correspondence,
- military reports,
- security memoranda,
- Legislative Council discussions,
- emergency legislation and Government Gazette notices,
- reports concerning Chinese secret societies,
- and correspondence relating directly to the Penang disturbances and subsequent security measures implemented within the Straits Settlements.

Particular reliance has been placed upon material within CO 273/11 and CO 273/12 concerning the Penang disturbances themselves, together with selected primary source correspondence within CO 273/5, CO 273/61 and CO 273/74 relating to the Larut disturbances and wider regional mobilisation networks connected to Penang and the western Malay Peninsula.

The records examined include correspondence concerning:

- the outbreak of the riots,
- organised secret-society mobilisation,
- military weakness within Penang,
- emergency troop and naval reinforcement measures,
- communal violence and urban security conditions,
- emergency legislation and disarmament operations,
- and the establishment of commissions of inquiry following the disturbances.

The study also considered later discussions and reproductions relating to the Penang Commission of Enquiry materials where relevant to subsequent narratives concerning the disturbances.

The methodology adopted in this study involves close examination of colonial-era correspondence together with comparison against later historical summaries concerning the Penang Riots.

Particular emphasis has been placed upon how British colonial authorities themselves interpreted the disturbances, assessed the security situation within Penang and responded to the crisis through the surviving original documentary record.

Introduction

The Penang Riots of 1867 occupy an important place within the history of the Straits Settlements. Later historical summaries commonly describe the disturbances as violent clashes between rival Chinese secret societies arising from longstanding communal rivalry between the Hai San and Ghee Hin organisations.¹

The surviving Colonial Office correspondence, however, reveals a considerably broader and more alarming situation than many later simplified narratives imply.² British officials repeatedly expressed concern regarding organised communal mobilisation, weakened military capability, inadequate policing strength and the possibility that colonial authorities might lose effective control over public order within Penang itself.³

Contemporary reports further suggest that British authorities increasingly viewed the disturbances as exposing deeper structural weaknesses within colonial security arrangements inside the Straits Settlements. Officials feared that the violence might spread beyond the immediate conflict between rival Chinese secret societies and draw wider sections of the population into the disturbances.⁴⁵

The riots unfolded during a period when Penang's military position had already been weakened by reductions in troop strength and the withdrawal of artillery and detachments connected to the Nicobar Islands expedition.⁶ Contemporary reports further acknowledged official fears that rival secret-society factions believed Government authority could be challenged without immediate military suppression.⁷

This paper reconsiders the Penang Riots through Colonial Office records. Particular attention is given to:

- the conditions leading to the riots,
- organised secret-society mobilisation,
- the escalation of violence within Penang itself,
- British fears during the disturbances,
- military weakness and emergency reinforcement measures,
- and the emergency responses implemented by colonial authorities following the restoration of order.

Read together with primary source evidence relating to the Larut disturbances, the surviving records further suggest that the Penang Riots may be better understood not merely as an isolated urban disturbance, but as part of a wider regional environment involving organised factional rivalry, labour mobilisation, commercial competition and growing British anxieties regarding security and governance within the Straits Settlements.

Penang Before the Riots

By the mid-nineteenth century, Penang had developed into one of the principal commercial centres of the Straits Settlements. The Settlement attracted large immigrant populations from China, India and the Malay world. Within the Chinese population, numerous secret societies, kongsi associations and clan organisations had emerged.⁸

British officials increasingly regarded several of these societies not merely as ordinary communal associations but as powerful organised bodies operating partly beyond effective colonial supervision.⁹ Contemporary correspondence further described extensive leadership hierarchies and systems of internal discipline capable of mobilising large numbers of followers with considerable speed and coordination.¹⁰

Colonial officials believed that several of the principal societies possessed memberships numbering in the many thousands. One report estimated that one society alone possessed approximately twenty thousand members while another reportedly numbered around nine thousand.¹¹ Other correspondence suggested that much of Penang's wider Chinese population belonged to one or another of the principal secret societies.¹²

The records also reveal growing British concern regarding the societies' systems of communication, internal discipline and mobilisation capacity. Officials increasingly portrayed the organisations as powerful bodies operating partly beyond effective colonial supervision and capable of rallying substantial support under influential leaders.^{13 14}

At the same time, Penang's military position appears to have been weak. The correspondence repeatedly referred to inadequate troop numbers, insufficient police strength and weak defensive capability within the Settlement.¹⁵ These weaknesses would become critically important once violence erupted.

The Outbreak of the Riots

The archival material suggests that disturbances had already begun by July 1867. One report stated that the "first case of rioting occurred in the beginning of July and lasted upwards of a week."¹⁶ During this period, houses were reportedly burned, property destroyed and at least one murder committed.¹⁷

Although temporary peace was arranged through mediation by leading members of other societies, the settlement proved fragile and short-lived.¹⁸ The correspondence suggests that the disturbances were not merely spontaneous street disorder arising from isolated quarrels or later simplified trigger narratives. The records instead point

toward deeper organised rivalry between large secret-society networks possessing substantial membership, internal authority and mobilisation capacity within Penang and the wider Straits Settlements.¹⁹

Read together with Colonial Office correspondence relating to the Larut disturbances, the evidence further suggests that Penang functioned as an important regional centre connected to Chinese commercial capital, labour organisation, maritime transport and the tin-mining economy of Larut and Perak. Earlier records concerning the First Larut War had already referred to organised mobilisation between Penang and Larut, concealed weapons aboard junks and British fears regarding wider regional disorder.²⁰ Later correspondence relating to the Larut disturbances of the early 1870s similarly pointed toward influential Penang-based supporters, financial backing and continuing struggles connected to the mining economy.²¹

Popular accounts sometimes attribute the riots to a dispute involving a “rambutan skin,” a narrative later associated with reproductions and discussions of the Penang Commission of Enquiry records.^{22a} The surviving Colonial Office correspondence examined in this study, however, points toward deeper organised rivalry, commercial competition and wider structural tensions operating within Penang and the western Malay Peninsula during this period.

The situation appears to have worsened significantly following reductions in military resources within Penang itself. Colonial correspondence acknowledged that artillery and military detachments had previously been withdrawn from the Settlement, thereby weakening its defensive position. One report further stated that the “lamentable results” of the disturbances were “entirely due to the absence of a sufficient force of troops to overawe the rioters” and argued that the Chinese societies would not have chosen that moment for their outbreak had the garrison remained at its “usual strength.”²²

Colonial correspondence further stated that Penang’s weakened defensive position had been aggravated by the withdrawal of artillery and the diversion of troops to the Nicobar Islands expedition in 1867.²³ Officials acknowledged that these reductions left only a limited remaining force within the Settlement and contributed to perceptions that Government authority could be challenged without immediate military suppression.²⁴

The riots soon intensified into widespread urban conflict involving barricaded streets, armed mobilisation, arson, looting and exchanges of musket fire throughout Penang.²⁵ Contemporary reports referred to “a promiscuous fire of musketry throughout the Town” while some correspondence further alleged that small cannon had been mounted upon rooftops and discharged during the disturbances.²⁶

The violence spread beyond the central town districts into surrounding settlements and villages. Reports stated that numerous houses had been burned and plundered, while portions of Jelutong were described as having been destroyed during the disturbances.²⁷ Colonial authorities admitted that the true number of casualties could not be determined because participants allegedly removed and concealed the bodies of their dead in secret burials after the fighting.²⁸

Some colonial correspondence further alleged that participation in the disturbances extended beyond the rival Chinese secret societies themselves. One report claimed that attempts had been made to attach "the Mahomedan part of the population" to the disturbances and alleged that "large numbers of Malays and other Natives" had taken part in the riots.²⁹ The correspondence additionally reveals that British officials feared the disturbances might expand into a broader communal security crisis involving additional sections of Penang's population beyond the rival Chinese societies themselves. One report warned that the introduction of the "Malay element" into the conflict was "what is most to be feared."³⁰

Colonial officials increasingly feared that the disturbances might escalate into broader communal conflict beyond the rival Chinese secret societies themselves. One report warned that thousands of armed men had nearly been allowed to "fight out their quarrel in the midst" of the town, while another expressed concern that wider sections of the population might eventually become drawn into the violence.³¹³²

British Reaction During the Crisis

One of the strongest recurring themes within the correspondence concerns British anxieties regarding inadequate military and policing capacity within Penang.

Contemporary correspondence repeatedly referred to inadequate troop strength, weak policing capability and fears that Government authority might appear unable to suppress large-scale disturbances effectively.³³ One especially revealing report stated that the riots resulted from the absence of sufficient troops to "overawe the rioters," while other correspondence suggested that rival secret-society factions increasingly believed the weakened military position within Penang prevented immediate suppression by the authorities.³⁴³⁵³⁶

The correspondence further reveals the scale of emergency mobilisation undertaken by colonial authorities once the disturbances intensified. Reports stated that "every soldier and policeman, and every European inhabitant" who could assist was called out during the crisis.³⁷ Streets were barricaded in attempts to prevent rival armed groups from coming into direct conflict within the town itself.³⁸

The correspondence described the disturbances as conditions approaching organised urban conflict involving thousands of armed men confronting one another

within Penang.³⁹ British officials further believed that the riots had exposed serious weaknesses within existing colonial security arrangements. One report stated that “the laws in force in these Settlements for the preservation of peace in time of disturbance were altogether insufficient,” while other correspondence warned that perceptions of Government weakness had encouraged organised disorder and communal mobilisation.⁴⁰⁴¹

In response, colonial authorities increasingly advocated broader emergency powers, including expanded detention authority, deportation provisions and temporary suspension of ordinary legal protections during periods of proclaimed disturbance.⁴² The records further reveal debate within the colonial administration regarding the proper balance between repression and stability. Some officials warned against introducing excessively harsh legislation that might provoke wider resistance among the Chinese population.⁴³

As the disturbances escalated, the authorities sought additional military and naval assistance. The correspondence referred to uncertainty regarding the return of HMS *Wasp* and HMS *Satellite*, which had earlier been deployed to the Nicobar Islands expedition prior to the outbreak of the riots.⁴⁴ In light of this uncertainty, requests were made for reinforcement support from Singapore, following which subsequent reports referred to the arrival of HMS *Rifleman* and the landing of naval personnel to assist exhausted troops and police forces within Penang.⁴⁵

The records repeatedly emphasised the importance of these reinforcements. Contemporary correspondence expressed official appreciation to Captain Bedingfeld R.N. together with the officers and men of H.M.S. *Wasp*, who assisted in relieving exhausted forces during the later stages of the disturbances.⁴⁶ Contemporary correspondence also praised the conduct of troops, police, naval personnel and civilian volunteers who assisted in maintaining order during the emergency.⁴⁷

The Immediate Aftermath

The riots triggered rapid expansion of emergency executive powers within Penang.

The records reveal that colonial authorities invoked emergency legislation and sought authority to implement broader provisions of the law in order to preserve “the peace of the Settlement.”⁴⁸ One report recommended the “immediate disarmament” of the town and surrounding districts.⁴⁹

The surviving records further reveal that extraordinary disarmament measures were formally implemented through the Straits Settlements Government Gazette Extraordinary issued on 17 August 1867. The emergency orders required inhabitants within Penang to surrender firearms, bayonets, swords, daggers, spears, gunpowder

and other weapons to the police authorities, while also authorising searches, confiscation of concealed arms and penalties for violations.⁵⁰⁵¹

These measures demonstrate that colonial authorities regarded the disturbances not merely as ordinary criminal disorder, but as a serious armed security crisis requiring exceptional executive intervention. Contemporary correspondence further suggested that Province Wellesley was temporarily exempted from certain emergency measures partly because the Government lacked sufficient force to enforce them effectively in the event of resistance.⁵²

The records further indicate that colonial authorities increasingly considered stronger long-term security measures following the riots, including expanded armed policing, increased troop strength, registration and supervision of secret societies and broader emergency powers enabling more rapid executive intervention during future disturbances.⁵³⁵⁴⁵⁵

Particularly significant are reports indicating that rival secret societies internally determined compensation arrangements "without our interference."⁵⁶ Read together with wider correspondence concerning leadership structures and communal discipline, this suggests that the principal societies possessed substantial systems of internal authority operating partly outside formal colonial structures.

The disturbances also led to the establishment of a formal Commission of Inquiry into the "origin and circumstances of the late riots at Penang."⁵⁷ The commission included European officials together with Chinese and Malay representatives familiar with local affairs.⁵⁸

Post-riot legislation further included indemnity provisions protecting Government officers and other persons for actions undertaken during the disturbances. This reflected the extraordinary legal circumstances arising from the crisis itself.⁵⁹

The records further indicate that the emergency measures implemented within Penang attracted the attention of the Colonial Office in London. Contemporary endorsements accompanying the correspondence indicated support for the proceedings undertaken following the riots.⁶⁰

During this period, Penang was administered by Lieutenant-Governor A. E. H. Anson, under whose authority extraordinary Government Gazette notices authorised stricter security controls and emergency measures within the Settlement.⁶¹

The surviving correspondence therefore suggests that the Penang disturbances stimulated broader colonial reconsideration of emergency powers, public-order administration and security governance within the Straits Settlements.

Conclusion

The surviving Colonial Office correspondence suggests that the Penang Riots of 1867 were considerably more serious than many later simplified narratives imply. The records reveal not merely spontaneous communal violence between rival secret societies, but a broader colonial security crisis involving organised mobilisation, weakened military capability and growing British fears regarding the maintenance of public order within Penang itself.

Popular accounts sometimes attribute the riots to a dispute involving a “rambutan skin.” The surviving Colonial Office correspondence examined in this study, however, points toward deeper organised rivalry, communal mobilisation, commercial competition and wider structural tensions operating within Penang and the western Malay Peninsula during this period.

Read together with contemporaneous evidence relating to the Larut disturbances, the records further suggest that the Penang Riots should not be understood solely as an isolated urban disturbance confined within George Town. The riots exposed significant weaknesses within colonial security arrangements and contributed to the expansion of emergency legislation, disarmament operations and executive powers within the Straits Settlements.

The surviving evidence therefore suggests that the Penang disturbances of 1867 represented not merely a communal riot, but an important episode in the development of colonial security governance and emergency rule in British Malaya.

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Endnotes

1. See, for example, Khoo Kay Kim, *The Western Malay States 1850–1873: The Effects of Commercial Development on Malay Politics* (Kuala Lumpur: Oxford University Press, 1972), on Penang's commercial development, immigration and Chinese secret societies within the Straits Settlements.
2. British Colonial Office Records, The National Archives (Kew, United Kingdom), CO 273/11, correspondence relating to the Penang disturbances and security conditions within the Straits Settlements during 1867.
3. CO 273/11, pp. 524–535.
4. CO 273/11, pp. 495–496, pp. 511–512, p. 537.
5. CO 273/11, p. 502, pp. 512–513.
6. CO 273/11, p. 499.
7. CO 273/11, pp. 499–500, correspondence concerning weakened military conditions within Penang.
8. See, for example, Khoo Kay Kim, *The Western Malay States 1850–1873: The Effects of Commercial Development on Malay Politics* (Kuala Lumpur: Oxford University Press, 1972).
9. CO 273/11, pp. 495–499, British concerns regarding secret-society influence.
10. CO 273/11, pp. 495–496, pp. 511–512, pp. 534–537, correspondence concerning secret-society organisation and mobilisation.
11. CO 273/11, pp. 495–496, reports estimating the Ghee Hin society at about twenty thousand members and the Twa Peh Kong at about nine thousand.
12. CO 273/11, p. 510–511.
13. CO 273/11, pp. 550.
14. CO 273/11, pp. 511–512.
15. CO 273/11, pp. 523–524.
16. CO 273/11, p. 498.
17. Ibid.

18. CO 273/11, pp. 498–500.
19. CO 273/11, pp. 495–496, pp. 511–512, p. 537, correspondence concerning secret-society organisation, leadership structures and mobilisation capacity.
20. CO 273/5, pp. 831, 843, 845, 847, reports concerning armed mobilisation between Penang and Larut, concealed weapons aboard junks and British fears of wider disorder during the Larut disturbances of 1861–1862.
21. CO 273/61, p. 496; see also CO 273/74, p. 284, discussions concerning influential Penang supporters, armed mobilisation, commercial rivalry and regional instability connected to the Larut disturbances.
22. CO 273/11, pp. 523–524, correspondence discussing reductions in military strength within Penang and stating that the disturbances resulted from the absence of sufficient troops and artillery to “overawe the rioters.”
- 22a. See, for example, later discussions and reproductions referring to the *Report of the Commissioners Appointed under Act XXI of 1867 to Enquire into The Penang Riots* (Penang Historical Society, 1955 reprint), which describe an altercation involving a “rambutan skin” prior to the escalation of violence. See also Lawrence Chua, “Part 1: Race and Rambutans,” *Site and Space in Southeast Asia*.
23. CO 273/11, p. 499, correspondence discussing the withdrawal of artillery and diversion of military resources from Penang to the Nicobar Islands expedition prior to the disturbances.
24. CO 273/11, pp. 499–500.
25. CO 273/11, pp. 500–503.
26. CO 273/11, pp. 503–504.
27. CO 273/11, p. 502.
28. CO 273/11, p. 504, references alleging that bodies had been “carried off ... secretly.”
29. CO 273/11, p. 497.
30. CO 273/11, p. 513.

31. CO 273/11, p. 501.
32. CO 273/11, pp. 513–514.
33. CO 273/11, pp. 531–535.
34. CO 273/11, pp. 523–524, reports stating that the disturbances resulted from the absence of sufficient troops to “overawe the rioters.”
35. CO 273/11, p. 548, warning that Government must not appear “unable or unwilling” to assume authority during the disturbances.
36. CO 273/11, p. 499.
37. CO 273/11, p. 500.
38. CO 273/11, p. 501.
39. CO 273/11, pp. 501–506.
40. CO 273/12, p. 53, reports stating that “the laws in force in these Settlements for the preservation of peace in time of disturbance were altogether insufficient.”
41. CO 273/12, p. 58, references to “the weakness of the Government and its inability to strengthen itself.”
42. CO 273/12, pp. 55–58.
43. CO 273/11, pp. 518–519, discussions warning against excessively repressive legislation that might provoke wider resistance.
44. CO 273/11, pp. 507–508, correspondence concerning HMS *Wasp*, HMS *Satellite* and reinforcement requests connected to the disturbances.
45. CO 273/11, pp. 507–508, reports concerning HMS *Rifleman*, naval landings and reinforcement operations within Penang.
46. CO 273/11, p. 522, correspondence expressing official thanks to Captain Bedingfeld R.N. and the officers and men of H.M.S. *Wasp* for assistance rendered during the later stages of the Penang disturbances.
47. CO 273/11, pp. 521–522, correspondence praising the conduct of troops, police, naval personnel and civilian volunteers during the disturbances.

48. CO 273/11, pp. 561–565, discussions regarding emergency legislation and expanded Government powers.

49. Ibid.

50. CO 273/11, p. 575.

51. Ibid., Police Notice signed by Commissioner of Police P. W. Earl concerning searches and confiscation of arms.

52. Ibid., noting that “Province Wellesley is for the present exempted from the operation of this notice.”

53. CO 273/11, pp. 563–564.

54. CO 273/11, pp. 564–565.

55. CO 273/12, pp. 53–58, discussions concerning expanded security powers, emergency legislation, armed policing and strengthened executive authority following the disturbances.

56. CO 273/11, p. 521, report on rival societies will settle compensation and losses internally without Government interference.

57. CO 273/11, p. 560.

58. CO 273/11, pp. 560–561.

59. CO 273/12, pp. 40, 44.

60. CO 273/11, pp. 569–570.

61. CO 273/11, pp. 563–565; 571–575.